the first full year of the operation of this scheme, a total of 43.64 lakh informal sector workers were registered under the scheme, a little less than 1 per cent of the targeted 50 crore. Enrolments under the scheme slowed down in financial year 2020–21. By 30 June 2020, enrolments increased to only 44.14 lakh and by 30 September 2020 to only 44.53 lakh. In six months, not even 1 lakh new workers registered for the PM-SYM. This might have been on account of the larger distress caused by COVID-19 and job losses caused by the lockdown. Even in the third quarter of 2020 (October–December) and fourth quarter (January–March), the enrolments did not pick up. The number of workers enrolled as on 31 March 2021, as per the numbers released by MoLE, was only 44.96 lakh. The scheme has completely stalled as additions in the first eight months of year 2021–22 were less than 15,000 a month.

It has been over two and a half years since the scheme was launched—total registrations are only about 45 lakh, less than 1 per cent of targeted workers.

The Labour and Employment Challenge is Massive

India's policymakers face a massive labour and employment challenge. The dimensions of these daunting challenges are as follows.

First, a very large proportion of people of working age (fifteen-plus) is not in the workforce. About 60 per cent of Indians of working age are neither employed, nor underemployed, which means three-fifth of our labour does not contribute to the formal economy of India by not participating in the production of goods and services at all. It is indeed a huge loss of growth potential.

Second, about 80 per cent of Indian women of working age are not in the labour force, making India one of the worst countries in this regard globally.